Mom Is in the Hospital and Discharge Is Coming Up: What to Sort Out First

Four moves, in order, and what can wait until you have more answers.

Someone at the hospital said the word “discharge” today. Since then you've been handed papers, dates and opinions by several different people, and none of it sits in one place.

Start here. Four things, in this order. All four are things to write down or ask. None of them is a decision.

1 Write down what changed

In a few lines, in your own words: what brought Mom to the hospital, when, and what you've been told since, with who said it. Put a question mark beside anything you're assuming and anything you only heard in passing.

WHY THIS COMES FIRST The story has been told in pieces to different people. Once it's written down in order, you can see what you actually know.

2 Find your point person, and say you want to be part of the planning

Ask who is handling Mom's discharge planning. It may be a dedicated discharge planner, a social worker, a nurse or another member of staff. Write down their name and number, tell them you want to be involved, and ask which dates have been set so far. Note each date and who gave it to you. [1] [2]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST The questions that follow need someone to go to. One name and one phone number save a lot of asking around.

3 Note where Mom needs help today

Write what you've seen on your visits this week: bathing, dressing, eating, using the toilet, getting in and out of the bed or a chair, taking her medications. For each one, note what she does on her own, where someone helps, and what you haven't seen. [3]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST The people planning her care will ask about everyday activities. What you've seen with your own eyes is the part only the family can supply.

4 Start one list of questions, with the money questions on their own page

Write every question down as it comes up, with who it belongs to: the discharge planner, the doctors, nurses and therapists, or the business office. Ask for instructions and guidance in writing. Take questions about payment directly to the people who know: the hospital or facility, Mom's insurer, or Medicare. [1]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST A written question gets asked. And a question taken to the right desk gets an answer you can use.

What can wait until you have more answers

- Which kind of care or care setting fits Mom. That comes from the people who assess her, and your notes help them.
- Deciding how her care will be paid for over the longer run.
- Working out anything about Medicaid, property or legal papers yourself. Those are questions for the right professional. Write yours down as they come up and bring them to your Medicaid planner.
- Who in the family does what in the months ahead.

One thing to say out loud

If the plan being discussed counts on you (your time, your strength, your home) and you have limits, say so. The Family Caregiver Alliance's discharge guide says discharge planners should talk with you about your willingness and ability to provide care, and that it's important to tell them about any limitations.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't interpret a notice or a bill, say what Medicare or Medicaid covers, or decide where Mom goes next. It puts your first few moves in order. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You've written down what changed, where Mom needs help today, and the questions that are still open. The care interview takes it from there: it walks you through Mom's situation area by area and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Who the point person may be, the advice to ask for instructions in writing, where to take payment questions, and telling staff about your limits follow the Family Caregiver Alliance's discharge guide. Telling the staff you want to be involved follows Medicare.gov's page on care planning in skilled nursing facilities. The everyday activities are the Administration for Community Living's list, with medications added from its list of everyday tasks. The order is ours.

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers
2. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Assessments & care plans in Skilled Nursing Facilities
3. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), What is Long-Term Care?